

at it like a seven-star or a five-star hotel. We've tried to keep our costs in control by trying to run a tight ship and bring a differentiated product," says Ghodawat.

On future growth, the company plans to narrow operations to just two types of fleet—a feeder network that flies smaller aircraft and larger aircraft focusing on point-to-point connectivity.

Chacko lists a few fundamental aviation survival principles—commit to one type of aircraft, don't mix your fleet, and keep operations simple.

"We call ourselves an air transportation company, with a plan to have five bases over the next five years. So, 30 aircraft, five years, build a pan-India network, a simple point-to-point service. Our plan is to connect district capitals to Tier II, Tier III cities, and state capitals. You take people from these cities into mainstream cities," he says.

Regional airlines have adopted innovative ways to lower administrative and allied costs. Fly91, for instance, doesn't have a call centre and has a fully automated bot that responds to customer queries. If they have more queries, customers can leave their phone number to get a return call from the airline. Star Air intentionally decided not to hire "very expensive" top management figures. It consciously looks for personnel who, it says, can promote team spirit.

MAN AND THE MACHINE

One of the challenges facing aviation is the availability of trained pilots and supply chain shortage.

India would need 30,000 pilots in the next 15 years with 1,500 new aircraft on order. Currently, there are around 8,000 pilots for the commercial passenger fleet



"ALMOST 60% OF THE ROUTES EVEN POST-UDAN CONTINUE TO WORK WITHOUT ANY ASSISTANCE AND WE ARE PROFITABLE ON THOSE SEGMENTS AS WELL"

SHRENIK GHODAWAT
MANAGING DIRECTOR,
GHODAWAT GROUP



"ANY CITY PAIR THAT IS MORE THAN SEVEN HOURS BY ROAD IS A CLASSIC OPPORTUNITY FOR REGIONAL AVIATION"

MANOJ CHACKO
MANAGING DIRECTOR & CEO, FLY91

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of over 800 aircraft, but 2,000-3,000 of them are not active aviators.

India's pilot training infrastructure is inadequate and a majority its pilots are trained abroad.

Khushbeg Jattana, General Manager of pilot training school Simaero India, says India needs to expand the number of flight schools from the current 37, which is just one-third of what the country requires.

"We will need flight schools with some 100 aircraft doing training. We do not have flight schools with more than 50 aircraft right now. So we need massive expansion on the aircraft side in the flight schools. Then comes the

second part where you have to do the simulator training," he says.

French aviation training company Simareo has announced a \$100 million investment in India for setting up world-class pilot training centres.

The first simulator is expected to be up and running by March next year. The company is in talks with regional players to set up simulators for training on smaller aircraft.

"We expect that another 40 simulators will be required in the next five years in India, at least to cater to the five-year expansion, and beyond that, I believe we'll need around 100 simulators in total in the next 10 years," it says.